later, I got a threatening phone call. ‘You have likened our leader to a dog. You and your family will pay for this. We will cut you into pieces.’

I was tempted to call the police but decided not to in the end. I had complained to Modi once about the abuse. *‘Galat hai,’* he said, *‘lekin mein har vyakti ko kaise rok sakta hoon’* (It is wrong, but how do I stop everyone who speaks). I found it difficult to accept that a politician who had such overwhelming control over his party faithful could be so helpless. Maybe it was just a crank call, but it reflected just how a robust medium of communication could just as easily become a rather noxious chamber of nastiness.

Were these anonymous Twitter trolls hand in glove with the BJP party machinery? A BJP insider admitted to me that there was a ‘media watch’ group of party volunteers who were tasked to ‘take down’ Modi’s critics. Whether they were ‘paid’ volunteers is unclear (a Cobrapost sting operation had shown how IT companies could be used to artificially hype up a politician’s image or malign his opponents). Some of the most abusive Twitter activists seemed to be linked to either pro-BJP websites or even individual party members. But Arvind Gupta, who headed the BJP’s IT cell, strongly denied the linkages. ‘No question about it, we would never support such behaviour,’ he insisted.

I wasn’t convinced. The campaign was much too organized for it not to have at least some level of endorsement from the leadership. The ‘HDL’, or Hindu Defence League, on Twitter was like a swarm of bees that would sting anyone who questioned their political beliefs. This wasn’t healthy debate—it was vile abuse being spewed under the cloak of anonymity. One of my perennial Internet Hindu abusers even rang me up once and invited me for a conference on Hinduism. I was tempted to attend, if only for a bit of fun, but eventually backed off. It isn’t as if parties like the Congress and AAP don’t have their fair share of Internet trolls, it’s just that they aren’t as mobilized on social media.

And yet, trolling cannot detract from the more positive aspects of the BJP’s well-structured social media campaign in 2014. Gupta spoke passionately about it over lunch at the India Habitat Centre. He struck me as